

COURSE OF THE FIRST WORLD WAR

Battle Fronts/War Fronts

Battle Front	Countries Involved
Western Front	Britain, France, Belgium and USA Vs Germany
Eastern Front	Russia Vs Germany and Austria-Hungary
Balkan Front	Romania, Serbia, Albania, Montenegro, Greece, Russia, Britain and France Vs Bulgaria, Turkey and Austria-Hungary
Gallipoli	Britain and France Vs Turkey
Middle East	Britain, France and India Vs Jordan and Turkey

Major Battles

Western Front	Eastern Front	Other battles
Marne	Tannenberg	Gallipoli
Ypres	Masurian lakes	Carporetto
Verdun	Brusilov offensive	Isonzo
Somme		Lemberg
Arras		Jutland
Mons		
Ludendorff offensive		

Weapons Used During First World War

Tanks, Poison gas, Machine guns, U-boats/ Submarines, Zeppelins/aeroplanes, Depth chargers, Hydrophones, Dreadnoughts, Howitzers, torpedos, grenades /bombs and mines.

Army leaders during the First World War

Britain	Germany	Russia:	France:	USA
Admiral Jellicoe	General Hindenburg	General Brusilov	General Foch	General Pershing
Admiral Craddock	General Falkenhayen	General Samsasonov	General Joffre	
Admiral Sturdee	General Ludendorff		General Petain	
Winston Churchill	General Moltke		General Galieni	
Lord Kitchener	General Sanders		General Serrail	
Douglas Haig (Field Marshal).	Admiral Scheer			
	Admiral Speer.			

The Schlieffen Plan

- It was a war plan designed by German General Chief of Staff by the name Count Alfred Von Schlieffen.
- The assumptions behind the plan:
 - (a) In any future war Germany would fight against France and Russia.
 - (b) Russian mobilization would be slow.
 - (c) France will be defeated and make peace within 6 weeks.
 - (d) Germany to face Russia after the capitulation or surrender of France.
 - (e) Belgium will be overrun or defeated easily.

Aims of the Schlieffen Plan

- To attack France through Belgium and Luxembourg.
- To fight both France and Russia in any future war.
- To avoid a two front war (Western front and Eastern front).
- To capture Paris in 6 weeks.
- To face Russia after the defeat of France.
- To ensure a quick victory in the Western front.
- To occupy channel ports in order to prevent landing of British reinforcements.
- To attack Paris from the west or rear.
- To fight Russia for 6 months in the Eastern front.

- Germany to be offensive or strike France first.

Design/Frame work of the Schlieffen plan

- Seven divisions or battalions of Germany army would attack or invade France through Belgium and Luxembourg.
- These forces were to be deployed on the basis of their strength.
- The extreme right wings of the 7th and 6th divisions were to be the strongest.
- The effectiveness of the plan was based on:
 - (a) Germany' superiority in numbers, organization, training and equipment.
 - (b) The effective use of railway lines to move troops.
- A large army of Germany (3 – 7 battalions) would attack France in a pincer or hammer formation.
- These battalions would make a flanking attack on Paris from the rear.
- Germany commanders in the flanking attack were to keep regular contacts with their central command.
- The army would receive regular supplies of food and ammunition.
- Germany forces were expected to conquer France in 6 weeks.
- The flanking attacking battalions were expected to establish free zones and deploy armies of occupation in defeated areas.
- The weaker battalions (1st and 2nd divisions) were to attack France first.
- These battalions were to engage French armies on the Franco-Germany boundary at the Alps Mountains.
- They were also expected to keep the French armies on that war front engaged until Germany Flanking battalions attacked them from the rear.

Outbreak of the war and Implementation of the Schlieffen Plan (How the plan was used)

- The Schlieffen Plan was put to use by Count Helmuth Von Moltke, the successor of Von Alfred Schlieffen.
- Moltke used the pincer or hammer attacking formation in the Western front offensive.
- Moltke made the following changes to the Schlieffen Plan:
 - a. He ordered the rightwing forces not to attack neutral Holland.
 - b. He strengthened the leftwing of German advance instead of the right wing.
 - c. Moltke withdrew some German divisions from the Schlieffen Plan attack and redeployed them to the Eastern front.
 - d. Germany commanders did not make a flanking attack on Paris instead they directly advanced towards Paris.
 - e. He assigned 3 instead of 2 divisions to directly engage through France on the common Franco-Germany boundary.
 - f. Germany commanders failed to keep regular contact with German High Command to keep posted or informed of new changes and new strategies.

Reasons for the failure of the Schlieffen Plan

- The plan failed to anticipate British entry into the war in defense of Belgium.
- The British Expeditionary Force (BEF) landed in France holding up the German advance at Mons
- Russia mobilised more quickly.
- Belgium put up stiffer resistance.
- Belgians destroyed railway lines
- German forces in Belgium were weakened when some forces were withdrawn to go and fight Russia.
- British resistance at Mons gave the French more time to prepare.
- Von Kluck Germany commander in France realized that he could not keep to the Schlieffen Plan.
- He changed the plan of attack.
- The French and the British checked the Germans at the river Marne.
- Germany was forced to retreat.
- British troops checked German forces at Ypres.
- Heat which affected German soldiers.
- Inadequate supply of resources.
- Fighting the war on two fronts.
- The death of Alfred Von Schlieffen.
- The plan was outdated.
- The plan was leaked to France.
- France had a counter plan called Plan 17.

Successes of the Schlieffen Plan

- German forces were able to advance into enemy zones.
- Germany entered France as far as 24 Km from Paris. They could see the Eiffel Tower from that point.
- Brussels was captured.
- German forces won early battles in both France and Belgium.
- Germany caused heavy casualties on the Allied powers in the early battles.

Failures of the Schlieffen Plan

- The Germans failed to give a quick blow to Belgium as was planned. The Belgian resistance held the Germans for 2 weeks.
- France was not conquered in 6 weeks as was planned.
- German soldiers failed to capture channel ports as per plan. The Allied powers successfully defended these ports.
- German commanders in the flanking attack worked as individuals and failed to keep regular contact with their central command.

- German forces lost regular supplies of food and reinforcements.
- Germany fought in two fronts against the principles or dictates of the Schlieffen plan.

Battles in the Western Front

Battle of Marne

- The Germans pursued the Schlieffen plan and marched through Belgium. They invaded Northern France.
- French armies were forced to retreat.
- The Germans advanced to within 32km of Paris.
- The French launched counter attack on the offensive of Germany.
- Private transport (taxis, personal cars and public buses) was used by the French to support the war effort.
- French troops under General Joffre and Gallieni stopped the Germans at River Marne and this was the beginning of the Battle of Marne.
- Business was stopped and schools were closed as the French defended their capital.
- The Germans suffered heavy casualties in this battle.
- The Germans were defeated.
- The Germans were pushed back (about 100km) to River Aisne.
- Moltke resigned.
- Marne battle ended in September 1914.
- The Germans did not surrender instead they dug trenches along the whole Western Front.

The Trench Warfare

- Trenches were defensive positions dug by Germany and Allied forces.
- They were introduced by the Germans at the end of battle of Marne as a way of avoiding surrender and continuous retreat against French counter attack.
- Trenches covered the whole of Western Front (stretched from Nieuport through Ypres, Arras, Sissions and Reins to Verdun).
- Soldiers fought from these trenches.
- Barbed wire was erected on the side facing the enemy.
- The territory between the two trenches was called '**no man's land.**'
- Trenches resulted in stalemates as neither side could advance.
- Trenches protected soldiers from gunfire explosions of artillery shells.
- Soldiers fought for days and months in order to get a small piece of land.
- Attack and counter attack became the order of the day.
- A gain of a few hundred yards resulted in heavy casualties for the side attempting to move forward.
- Trenches became soldiers' 'homes' or 'prisons'.
- Trench warfare lasted for the whole duration of the war.
- The trenches had the following effects or results:
 - Soldiers suffered from trench foot in winter because of standing in water for days.

- Cavalry tactics (soldiers on horsebacks) were replaced by infantry tactics.
- Many people were killed.
- Many soldiers were injured.
- Food shortages were experienced.
- Soldiers were also affected by frost bite.
- Trenches were hot and dusty in summer.
- Loss of morale as soldiers spent too much time in trenches.
- Trenches were smelly due to rotting corpses, sewage and unwashed bodies.
- War of position replaced war of movement.
- Trenches were infested with lice and rats ('fat corpse rats').
- They delayed the war.
- They also caused stalemates (no winner).
- Introduction of new weapons like poisonous gases, war planes and tanks.
- Trenches generated a sense of comradeship or unity among soldiers as they shared the dangers of war and unpleasant conditions.

Battle of Ypres, 1915

- Germany offensive in Belgium against the Allied Powers.
- Germany wanted to capture the Channel Ports.
- Germany attack did not yield any breakthrough to the Channel Ports.
- British losses were heavy.
- Germany Zeppelins bombed London and Yarmouth.
- As Zeppelins proved easy to shoot down, the Germans started using aeroplanes in aerial raids over England
- Germany introduced poisonous gas.
- Trenches were introduced at Ypres and stalemate continued in the Western Front.

Battle of Verdun, 1916

- This was an attack or offensive carried out by the Germans in February on France's stronghold or fortress of Verdun.
- German offensive was led by Falkenhayn and Moltke.
- The Germans had the following objectives or aims:
 - a. To release pressure on Marne.
 - b. To weaken Britain by conquering France.
 - c. To force France to withdraw her strongest armies from other battle fronts so as to defend Verdun their military centre.
 - d. To conquer the strongest French armies at Verdun and force her into surrender.
- The Germans believed that successful drive on Paris lay with the capture of Verdun.
- 19 Germany divisions heavily armed with artillery were directed to Verdun by General Moltke.
- A heavy artillery bombardment of Verdun was started followed by Germany Infantry.
- The French responded with artillery bombardment.

- Britain rushed to the assistance of France.
- Allied powers (Britain, Russia and Italy) launched new attacks on Germany in order to reduce pressure on Verdun.
- The French Marshal Petain strongly and successfully defended Verdun.
- The French slogan was ‘we did it at Marne, they shall not pass’.
- The Germans upon realisation that they could not conquer Verdun withdrew their soldiers from Verdun in June 1916.
- Both sides lost many soldiers.

Battle of Somme (May 1916)

- This was an Allied offensive against Germany on Somme.
- These were a series of attacks by the British on the Germans at Somme.
- These battles were planned and led by the British army under Field Marshal Douglas Haig.
- Haig conscripted volunteer armies in May 1916.
- This was more of a British undertaking because the French were tied up at Verdun.
- The British had the following aims:
 - a. To reduce pressure on Verdun.
 - b. To prevent Germany from sending reinforcements to the Eastern Front.
 - c. To divide German attention in order to weaken her attack on Verdun.
 - d. To keep Germany busy so as to tie her and weaken her.
- Germany pumped sewage downhill into the British trenches.
- Somme battles were suicidal because most of them were open field fights. Soldiers fought mainly on open spaces like valleys and plains.
- Germany lost most of her trained men.
- Britain introduced tanks for the first time.
- Tanks were sent to France disguised as water tankers in order to keep the secret from Germany.
- Tanks advanced ahead of the infantry, crushing barbed wire defenses and spraying the enemy with machine gun fire.
- However, tanks had short training before the Somme, some tanks broke down before reaching the battlefield and others were bogged in mud.
- Tanks were immediately successful but not enough were used to break the deadlock of the trenches.
- Somme battles were ended in November 1916.
- Haig stopped these attacks because he was heavily criticized for his volunteer schemes which caused heavy losses.
- No side claimed victory but the casualties (death and injuries) were high on both sides.

Battle of Arras, 1917

- The heaviest offensive undertaken by Britain.
- Germany army suffered serious damage.

- The British captured Vimy Ridge which was part of the Hindenburg line.
- Germany was able to hold on and only a few miles were gained by the attackers.
- The French under Neville launched a plan of capturing the immensely fortified heights to the north of River Aisne (Hindenburg line).
- The French offensive succeeded in capturing most of the heights.
- However, the casualties were so enormous that the offensive was brought to a halt.
- Neville offensive was followed by mutinies in the French army.
- Petain who replaced Neville used firing squads to suppress the mutineers.

Eastern Front

- Fighting involved Russia against Austria Hungary and Germany.
- In August 1914 Russia scored early successes in East Prussia and Galicia against Germany and Austria Hungary respectively.
- The Serbs even managed to recapture their capital Belgrade from the Austrians.
- Germany recalled Hindenburg from retirement and withdrew part of her forces in the Western Front and redeployed them to the Eastern Front to help Austria Hungary.
- Germans under Hindenburg and Ludendorff defeated the Russians at the battles of Tannenberg and Masurian Lakes in 1914.
- The Germans followed up these successes by driving the Russian armies out of Galicia, Lithuania, Colouredland and Poland.
- Warsaw, the Polish capital fell to the Germans in August 1915.
- Despite of all these military campaigns, there was a deadlock/stalemate (no winner) in the Eastern Front because:
 - a. Russian army was ill equipped and poorly led to break through.
 - b. Austrian army was inefficient as a result it failed to defeat Serbia to make a break through.
 - c. Austria directed most of its troops to fight the Italians.
 - d. Most of Germany soldiers were fighting in the Western Front.
- In June 1916 the Russians launched the **Brusilov offensive**.
- The offensive which was led by Brusilov broke the Austrian Front and captured 4000 prisoners and weapons.
- The Brusilov offensive contributed to the collapse of the Austro - Hungarian Empire.
- The Russian success persuaded Romania to join the Allied powers.
- Romania attacked Austria.
- Germany intervened and occupied the whole of Romania and seized her wheat and oil supplies.
- The Socialist Revolution of 1917 in Russia brought a Communist government into power. This new government ended the war with Germany by a treaty known as Brest-Litovsk.
- Russia under Brest Litovsk lost her industries and the following territories Estonia, Latvia, Poland, Lithuania, Ukraine, Georgia and Finland to Germany.

Gallipoli Campaign, 1915

- This was an Allied attack to conquer Turkey.
- The aim was to attack the Central powers from their weakest points (i.e. Turkey & Austria Hungary) which they called 'soft underbelly' of the Central Powers.
- Lloyd George described the campaign as, 'knocking out the props from under Germany'.
- Winston Churchill the head of the Royal Navy and Lord Kitchener the commander of the war effort persuaded the government to attempt an attack on the Dardanelles.
- The Royal Navy was expected to go through the Dardanelles, attack Constantinople and drive Turkey out of the war.
- The aims of Gallipoli campaign were to:
 - a. Open a sea route to the Russian Front in order to get supplies to the Russians.
 - b. Establish a new front so that the Allied troops could march through the Balkans and attack Austria Hungary.
 - c. Reduce pressure on the Russian Front.
- Warships began their assault in March 1915.
- They bombarded the strong forts that lined the straits and made their advance.
- The British and French ships hit mines and were attacked by shells from the forts on the shore as they entered the straits.
- Three battle cruisers were sunk and others were damaged.
- Allied naval attack on the Dardanelles failed.
- The Allied forces containing Australians and New Zealanders (ANZAC) landed on the Gallipoli peninsula in April 1915.
- The Allied forces occupied some beaches but some were fiercely defended by the Turks.
- Both sides lost many soldiers.
- Allied powers failed to capture Constantinople and withdrew from Gallipoli in 1916.
- The failure of this campaign resulted in Bulgaria joining the Central Powers.
- A combined force of Germany, Austria Hungary and Bulgaria defeated Serbia and Montenegro.
- Allied Powers lost control of the Balkans.

Problems faced by the Allied Powers on Gallipoli Campaign

- The straits had steep cliffs. This made it difficult to land troops.
- The coasts were bare and windswept with few bays.
- The water ways were mined.
- The land was well defended by troops under Germany command. General Sanders was in charge of Turkish defense.
- Lack of support from Land based troops/ground forces.
- The Turks had advantage of high ground.

The Balkan campaign

- Allied powers landed in Salonika in Greece in October 1915.
- Their aim was to help Serbia defeat Austria and Bulgaria and then create a new front against Germany.
- The campaign had the following problems: Russia was not comfortable working with the Greeks because of their rivalry in the Balkans and Greece was neutral and wanted to stay out of the war.
- Bulgarian resistance held Allied troops.
- A stalemate developed here again.
- Troops were affected by malaria and dysentery.
- The stalemate was broken in September 1918.
- The Bulgarians were defeated.

War at Sea or Naval Warfare

- This was the fighting in water (Seas & Oceans).
- It was mainly contested by Britain and Germany.
- U.S.A and Japan also took part in naval warfare.
- Some of the naval battles involved:
 - a. Battle of Falkland Islands.
 - b. Allied naval blockade.
 - c. Submarine warfare or German U-boat campaign.
 - d. Battle of Jutland
- Naval warfare started when Admiral Spee of German Pacific fleet sank and destroyed a small British Far Eastern Squadron under Admiral Craddock of the Coast of Chile.
- The Royal Navy responded by sending part of its Grand Royal fleet to the Falkland Islands to revenge the sinking of Far Eastern Squadron by the Germans.

Falkland Island Battle, 1914

- This was part of war at sea fought between Britain and Germany.
- It was planned by the British as a way of revenge for the sinking of British Far Eastern Squadron by Germany.
- Admiral Sturdee was given the responsibility of carrying out this revenge mission.
- Sturdee took 2 new battle ships and 5 cruisers to Falkland Islands.
- The Royal Navy used a fake radio signal to trick and lure a Germany fleet to Falkland Islands.
- Germany Navy under Von Spee arrived to attack the British on the Falkland Islands.
- The Germans found Falkland Islands fortified by British battleships.
- German fleet turned away and sped off.
- The British pursued them and sank 4 German ships.
- The Germans lost many sailors including Spee.
- Britain later introduced Allied Blockade on Germany.

Allied Blockade or Allied Naval Blockade

- It was the blocking of ships from leaving and entering areas of Central Powers.
- Ships of Central Powers were prevented from leaving Europe and other ships were prevented from entering the Central Powers.
- It was introduced by the British.
- The aims of Allied Blockade were to:
 - i. Prevent goods from leaving and entering Central Powers.
 - ii. Starve the Central Powers.
 - iii. Enable the Allied powers to get supplies of the war.
 - iv. Transport British troops to war zones.
 - v. Keep British troops deployed in France and Belgium well supplied via channel ports.
- The Royal Navy officials patrolled high seas and regulated ship movements.
- They stopped and inspected all vessels they encountered.
- They captured ships and goods meant for their enemies.
- The British Navy stopped and searched all neutral, military, civilian and cargo ships which they suspected to be destined for enemy hands.
- Central Powers were deprived of raw materials, war resources and their international trade was affected.
- Germany responded to this Blockade by introducing Submarine warfare.

Battle of Jutland

- It was a naval clash between Britain and Germany in 1916.
- It happened on Jutland Peninsula in Northern Denmark.
- It was launched by Admiral Von Scheer of Germany.
- He tried to trick the British Grand Fleet to get out of their base.
- He sent Admiral Hipper's battle cruiser squadron ahead into Jutland Peninsula as bait on the British Grand Fleet. His assumption was that only a few vessels would come out at a time.
- Admiral Jellicoe did not buy this trick instead he sent a large number of battle cruisers to attack the Germans.
- The two sides continuously shelled each other.
- Germany lost 11 ships and 2500 sailors while Britain lost 14 ships and 6000 sailors.
- The German fleet slipped away to its base at night.
- The fleet remained there until the end of the war.
- Both sides claimed victory.
- Allied blockade continued.

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Submarine Warfare or German U-boat Campaign

- It was part of war at sea.
- It was initiated by Admiral Scheer of Germany.

- Germany wanted to cut off British supply lines or to starve Britain by sinking her merchant ships.
- Germany adopted unrestricted submarine warfare.
- The Germans declared that the seas around the British Isles were a war zone in which enemy ships would be sunk.
- Germany sunk the British ship Lusitania which was carrying Americans and British civilian citizens.
- USA protested against German barbarism.
- Germany temporarily stopped the U-boat attacks.
- Germany resumed the unrestricted U-boat campaign in 1916.
- The Germans sank another British ship the Sussex which was carrying American civilians.
- The Campaign was successful initially as many British ships were sunk.
- The submarine warfare caused food shortages in Britain (Britain was left with only 6 weeks supply of food).
- Consequently, Britain introduced food rationing of the following commodities sugar, meat, butter, jam, marmalade, tea, coffee and chocolate biscuits.
- Britain used counter methods like use of
 - i. Convoy system (merchant ships were protected by war ships)
 - ii. Radar
 - iii. Depth chargers
 - iv. Hydrophones
- Britain survived because of an expansion of ship building, American entry and Japanese naval assistance.

Why did USA join the war in 1917?

USA joined the war because of the following reasons:

- The sinking of Lusitania and Sussex by Germany.
- Germany resumed unrestricted submarine warfare and sank many American ships.
- American sympathy to the Allied powers.
- The attempts by Germany to seek Mexican help in the fight against USA
 - In the Zimmermann telegram, Germany persuaded Mexico to declare war on USA so that on winning the World War 1 Mexico would get Arizona, Texas and New Texas.
- The alleged sabotage of US communication system by German agents in USA.
- Allied debts to USA. It was feared that if Germany won the war the debts may not be repaid.
- The Americans condemned Germany as the aggressor and disliked the invasion of Belgium.
- German militarism was regarded as a threat to democracy.

Ludendorff Offensive, 1918

- It was Germany's last offensive in the Western Front which was led by General Ludendorff.
- He wanted to break through the Allied lines before the arrival of American reinforcements.
- The offensive started with the attack of British lines at Arras.
- Ludendorff started with huge bombardment and gas attacks.
- He followed up with attacks by smaller bands of specially trained and lightly equipped soldiers.
- He took advantage of the heavy fog along the entire front line.
- The first stages of the onslaught were successful.
- German troops crossed the River Aisne and once again reached the Marne.
- Ludendorff broke through Allied lines in many places.
- German troops were now within 64km of Paris.
- Paris was in the range of gunfire.
- Many of the planned advances were held up as Germans stopped to loot food and supplies from the captured trenches and villages.
- However, by the time Ludendorff reached Marne he had lost over 50 000 soldiers.
- Problems encountered by Ludendorff included an undisciplined army, losing many soldiers, losing his experienced soldiers, food shortages, flu epidemic, demoralized army, lacked reserves or reinforcements and mutinies.
- The Allied forces retreated allowing the Germans to stretch themselves and giving time for the arrival of Americans.
- General Foch was the Allied commander.
- The arrival of 700 000 American troops boosted the Allied forces' morale and provided the most valuable reserves.
- The well fed Allied army was supported by tanks, aircraft and improved artillery.
- The big guns with improved accuracy provided smokescreen/cover for attackers.
- The Allied forces pushed the Germans back.
- Germany lost her earlier gains.
- Germany resistance became hopeless following the defeat of Bulgaria, Austria and Turkey.
- Mutinies broke out in Germany Navy.
- The Kaiser fled to neutral Holland.
- Germany agreed to an armistice which was signed in November of 1918.

End of the war

Reasons for the defeat of Germany

Germany was defeated because of the following reasons:

1. Failure of the Schlieffen plan

France was not conquered in 6 weeks as was planned. The Belgians put up a stiffer resistance and delayed the Germans. Russia mobilized more quickly and Germany was forced to fight on two fronts. Above all, the coming in of Britain to the aid of Belgium was not envisaged (considered) in the plan. These developments weakened German attack.

2. Allied Powers were more in numbers

This meant more weapons, food, soldiers and war ideas.

3. A joint Allied High command

The Allied powers joined their troops under one command in 1918. This gave them a unified strategy and improved the discipline of the troops. Their defense and offense was synchronized.

4. Failure of U-boat campaign

The unrestricted submarine warfare failed to destroy Britain and instead it brought USA into the war. The anti-submarine devices and the convoy system effectively protected Allied shipping.

5. The entry of USA into the war in 1917

The USA helped to effect naval blockade on Germany.

It brought loans, food, weapons and fresh soldiers to the Allied powers. This gave them a morale boost.

USA boosted the resources of the Allied powers at a time when the German resources were almost exhausted.

6. The Allied Blockade

The Allied Powers successfully blocked ships from Central Powers from leaving and entering Central Powers. This caused food shortages and lack of war supplies and raw-materials to the Central Powers while the Allied Powers were fully supplied. As a result, Germany lost her international markets and her army was weakened.

7. Weak Allies

Germany was constantly called to the aid of her allies. This reduced her impact against her enemies in the Western front and Eastern front.

8. Collapse of Turkish Empire

- Turkey directed her attention to fighting her own subjects and this denied Germany maximum support.

9. Collapse of Austria- Hungarian Empire

This deprived Germany of manpower and resources.

10. Failure of Ludendorff Offensive

Germans abandoned the trenches and stretched their manpower. Many experienced soldiers were lost by Germany in this campaign.

11. The defeat of Germany allies

Austria-Hungary, Turkey and Bulgaria were all defeated in 1918 and this weakened Germany's fighting spirit

12. Naval mutiny in 1918

German naval mutiny spread to other military groups and this weakened the morale of the army.

13. Social unrest in Germany, 1918

There was a revolution in Germany and this weakened the war effort.

14. Germany fought on many fronts

Germany and her allies fought the war on many fronts and this strained and overstretched their resources.

15. Competence of Allied war time leaders.

The Allied war time leaders (Lloyd George & George Clemenceau) were good leaders whose speeches and guidance inspired their nations to victory while the erratic Kaiser caused a mutiny.

16. Abdication of the Kaiser

This killed the morale of the army. The new government was prepared to negotiate for peace.